How To Pick a University Wisely



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FIRST, A WORD TO PARENTS. TAKE A CHILL PILL. STAY OUT OF THE PROCESS. Let the student take the lead. You have led the charge so far, through 15 years of pre-school and school. You've given them roots; that will be their foundation for their whole lives. Now, give them wings. It's their time to fly. Going to college is an important rite of passage, and allow them the autonomy to do it on their own. You are the safety net, the sounding board, but no longer the decision maker. They need to be independent, but never alone. So young folks, here are some home truths. You have already chosen the colleges available to you, by the marks you have scored in board exams. Don't be under any illusions that you will get into an IIT, if your marks are ITI level.

Yes, some private, deemed universities are less rigid about marks because they give weightage to extracurricular activities, and the way you perform in the entrance tests, group discussions and interviews. If you believe that your marks don't tell your whole story, then look for institutions that are willing to take a wider, more liberal view.

Please, please, don't buy your way into a prestigious, brand name college by paying ridiculous capitation fees. Their course will be rigorous, your co-students will be way ahead of you, and your years in college will be full of struggle and with a sense that you are not good enough. This can lead to burnout and drop out. Invest the money in a good mutual fund, and let it grow for 15 years. Find a college that is a good match for your abilities, and that will encourage and challenge you to stretch.

Why are you going to college anyway? To learn about life. To learn about making choices. To find areas of competence and passion. College will help you grow into a fully formed adult, ready for the world. You go to college to learn how to think. The days of rote learning and spoon feeding are over. Now, you will have to think if you are to succeed. You will learn to communicate, to interact with peers, and if you are good at this you will become a persuader, a leader. They call these soft skills but I call them 'life skills'. Years later, you may remember very little of the subjects you studied. You will always remember the teacher who challenged you to be better, or opened your mind to new possibilities. You also go to college to build a network of friends—your peeps who will be your source of support for the rest of your life. Find a group that is ambitious and are there to build their future. Hang out with them and you'll



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